

SENEGAL

FEBRUARY 2015 – JULY 2026

Prepared by Africa INSIGHTS Research Team | Vertical: Travel & Tourism

Senegal holds a solid perception score of 70 — tied at fourth in its peer group — but transport and cost drag are widening risks the board must address now.

1,114	68%	14%	18%	70/100
RECORDS IN VIEW	POSITIVE	NEUTRAL	NEGATIVE	PERCEPTION

01 MONTH IN REVIEW

Senegal enters the 2025–2026 stretch of the reporting window in a position of genuine, if fragile, strength. A **perception score of 70 out of 100** and a **net sentiment of 49.7** place the country comfortably above neutral, underpinned by outstanding scores for scenery and food that give the destination a clear emotional identity. The driving force behind this standing is the country's natural and cultural appeal — scenery alone accounts for the highest mention volume of any theme — but that strength is being partially offset by persistent friction on transport and a rising cost signal that, left unaddressed, will erode the goodwill that authenticity has built.

The single action the board should prioritise is a targeted intervention on transport perception. Transport is the most negatively rated reportable theme with a volume large enough to move the overall score, and it is the area where Senegal falls furthest behind its peer average. Messaging that repositions transport limitations as part of an adventurous, off-the-beaten-track experience buys time, but infrastructure advocacy and operator partnerships are the durable fix.

The period's most important structural positive is the long-run trajectory: perception has risen **27 points** from its 2015 baseline of **40**, demonstrating that improvements made in-market do register in the global conversation. That arc gives the board a compelling story to tell investors and policy makers — and a floor of credibility from which to make the case for further investment in the themes that are currently dragging the score down.

DATA NOTE

The 2015 base-year sample of 32 records falls below the 50-record threshold for year-level analysis, so the starting point of the long-run trend should be treated as directionally useful rather than statistically precise.

DATA NOTE

The period label runs to July 2026; the 2026 year-to-date figure therefore reflects only a partial year and cannot be compared directly to full-year scores for earlier periods.

02 PERCEPTION OVERVIEW

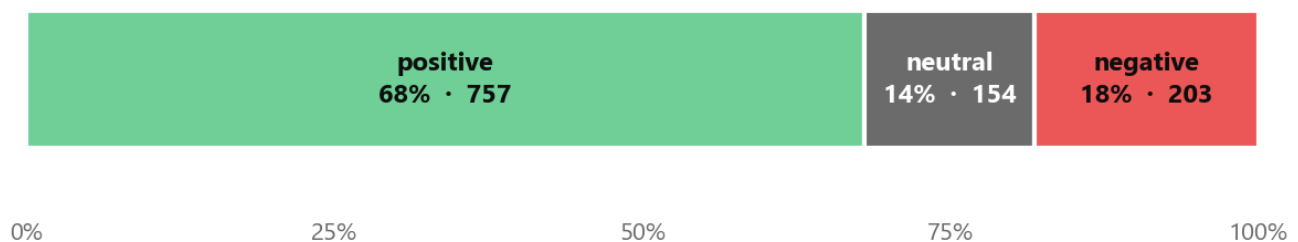
Senegal's **perception score of 70** on the 0–100 scale — where 50 represents neutral — signals a market that is clearly liked, not merely tolerated. A score this far into positive territory reflects a destination that has built genuine affinity rather than indifference. The **net sentiment of 49.7** reinforces this reading: positive opinion outruns negative opinion by nearly fifty points across the full sample of **1,114 records**.

The breakdown of sentiment — **68.0% positive, 13.8% neutral, and 18.2% negative** — tells a story of healthy majority approval alongside a minority of detractors large enough to warrant attention. The neutral share is relatively modest, which means most people who engage with Senegal's destination narrative form a clear opinion. That is a double-edged quality: it means marketing has traction and converts audiences, but it also means negative experiences are unlikely to stay neutral — they will crystallise into active detractors. The **18.2% negative share** is the metric to watch.

Emotionally, the record shows excitement as the dominant registered emotion, present across **14.5%** of all records. Longing — the desire to visit or return — accounts for a further **4.1%**. Together these two emotions are the hallmarks of a aspirational destination. Fear and disappointment are present but at low levels, which means the negative sentiment is concentrated in specific friction themes rather than being diffused across the whole experience. The board can therefore treat the negative share as a targeted problem rather than a reputational crisis.

Figure 1 — Sentiment breakdown

How the 1,114 records in view split across sentiment classes. Net sentiment is +50 points.



03 THEMATIC ANALYSIS

Scenery is Senegal's anchor asset and the most-mentioned reportable theme in the dataset, with **149 mentions** and a **net sentiment of 69.8**. Four in five mentions are positive, and the theme has been remarkably stable across the period — negative sentiment held at **12.0%** in the first half and barely moved to **12.2%** in the second. This consistency matters: scenery is not a momentary spike but a durable perception foundation. The voice of @Artificialintelligence-xd8pb (Nov 2019) captures the tone that recurs across the dataset — "Senegal is such a beautiful country with good people" — linking landscape and human warmth in a single impression that marketing should amplify rather than rearchitect.

Food and hospitality form the second tier of Senegal's strengths, both reportable and both strongly positive. **Food scores a net of 62.7** across 51 mentions, with nearly **76.5%** of comments positive — a standout in a regional peer group where the food net average sits at 39.0. **Hospitality nets 46.8** across 77 mentions, with just over two-thirds of comments positive. The important caveat on hospitality is that negative sentiment is not trivial at **22.1%**: more than one in five hospitality mentions is critical, suggesting that service quality is uneven rather than uniformly excellent. The theme is moving sideways — stable across both halves of the period — so the

unevenness is structural, not situational. Operators and accommodation providers need a quality-consistency programme, not a rebranding exercise. Food, by contrast, is worsening at a statistically reportable rate: negative mentions rose from **10.3%** in the first half to **18.2%** in the second, a trend that should prompt the board to investigate whether changing visitor profiles or supply-chain pressures are driving the shift.

Transport and cost are the two clearest drags on the score. **Transport nets -12.8** across 47 mentions — nearly half of all transport comments are negative — and the gap to the peer average is the widest of any reportable theme. **Cost nets -12.5** across 24 mentions, with negative comments outpacing positive ones. Housing is also a reportable theme but a nuanced one: a **net of 22.2** across 18 mentions is positive in direction, though the sample sits at the minimum threshold and the high neutral share (33.3%) means many visitors reserve judgement. **Safety nets -15.8** across 19 mentions, carrying the largest negative net of any reportable theme, though the improving trajectory across the period (discussed further in Section 06) is an important context. The long-time Dakar resident @phpn99 (May 2024) articulates a tension that underlies several of these themes simultaneously: praising the city's people and low crime while naming demographic pressure as a structural drag — a nuanced reading that more simplistic negative commentary does not capture, but which policy stakeholders should not dismiss.

DATA NOTE

Weather, water, and wildlife each fall below the 15-mention floor and are therefore excluded from headline findings in this section. Their signals are noted in the trends section where movement data exists but should not anchor any finding.

DATA NOTE

The food worsening trend is marked reportable in the movement data; however, the second-half sample for food (22 mentions) is relatively small and the trend should be monitored rather than treated as conclusive.

Voices behind the numbers

The most-engaged supportive and critical mentions in this view. Emoji and non-Latin characters are stripped for print.

POSITIVE · @noeltheliberalmillennial4886 · Feb 2021 · 1,723 likes · score +0.46

"Shea butter bae is cute..but no one is talking about the narrator. He is so informative. And the woman..resilient! Love and greetings from Kenya "

POSITIVE · @Artificialintelligence-xd8pb · Nov 2019 · 1,311 likes · score +0.77

"Senegal is such a beautiful country with good people big up from Kenya "

NEGATIVE · @hahahehehoho8191 · Mar 2021 · 2,748 likes · score -0.81

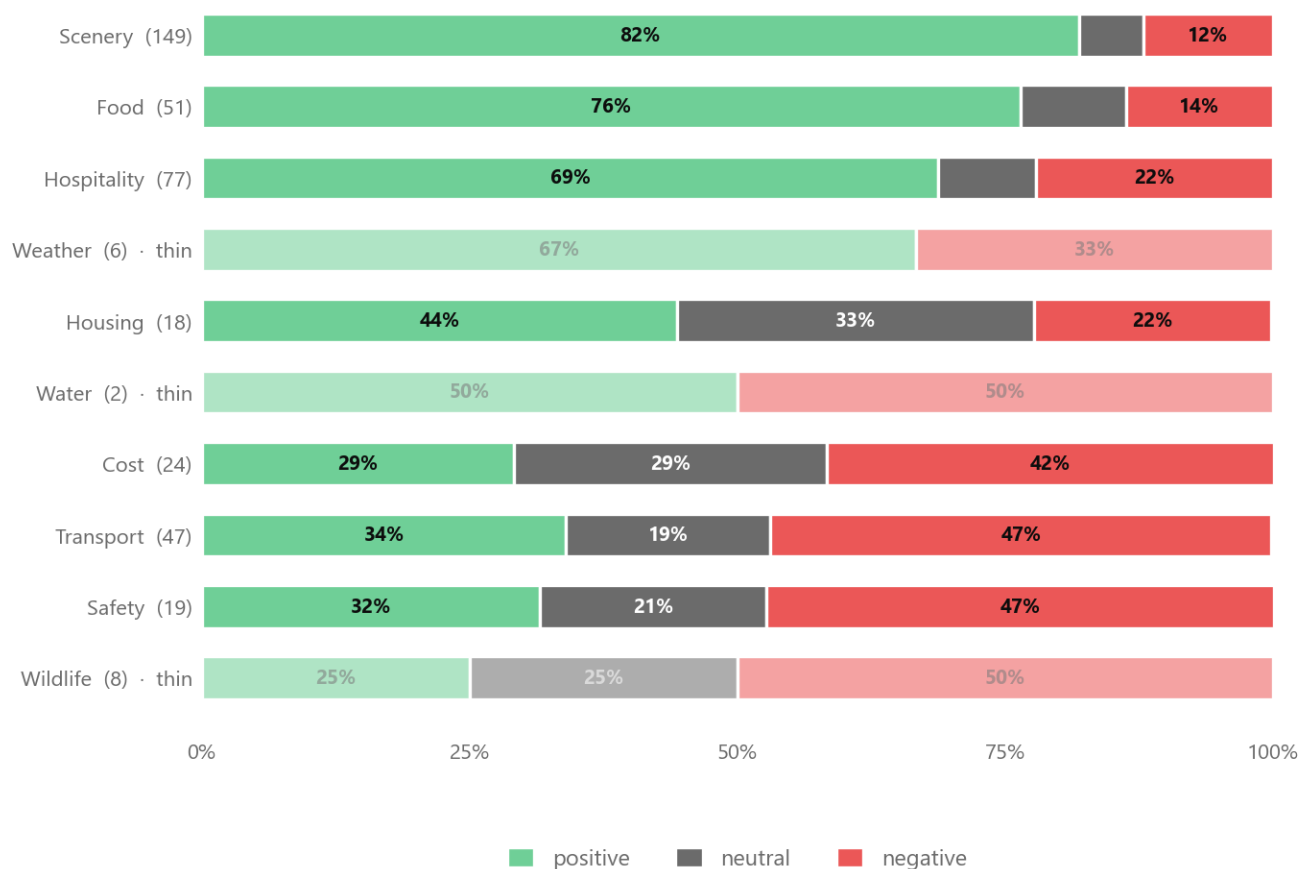
"When your job is so physically demanding that you get jacked without going to gym a single day"

NEGATIVE · @phpn99 · May 2024 · 316 likes · score -0.48

"I'm white. Been living in and out of Dakar for 30 years. As any city it has its down sides but overall it's been a wonderful place to live in. The people are very engaging ; the weather's great ; crime's low and you pretty much find everything you need, within limits. The major problem in Senegal i..."

Figure 2 — Sentiment by theme

Every travel theme mentioned in this view, ranked by net sentiment. Mention counts in brackets; themes below the 15-mention floor are faded and marked thin.



04 VISITOR SEGMENTS

The segments data reveals four distinct traveller cohorts — business, budget, luxury, and adventure — but none clears the **50-record threshold** required for cohort-level findings to be reported with confidence. Classified records account for only **4.6%** of the total sample, meaning the overwhelming majority of the **1,114 records** could not be assigned to a segment. No direct comparison between cohorts is possible within the evidence standards this report observes.

What the segment data does offer, at an indicative level, is a directional read that the board should use to guide further research rather than immediate budget allocation. The pattern visible across all four cohorts — adventure travellers appearing most positive, business travellers appearing most negative — would be a plausible and actionable finding if confirmed at scale. Business visitors in particular show an indicatively weak perception score, which would align with the transport and cost friction identified in the thematic analysis: these are precisely the pain points that matter most to time-sensitive, expense-conscious corporate travellers. The board should treat segment classification as a priority investment for the next data collection cycle.

DATA NOTE

No visitor cohort clears the 50-record minimum threshold. All four segment scores are indicative only and must not be used to headline findings, anchor recommendations, or be ranked against one another.

DATA NOTE

Only 4.6% of records could be classified into a segment, which limits the representativeness of any segment-level reading regardless of individual cohort sizes.

VISITOR SEGMENT	RECORDS	SHARE OF VIEW	PERCEPTION	NET
Business · thin	19	1.7%	44/100	-21
Budget · thin	14	1.3%	55/100	+7
Luxury · thin	14	1.3%	60/100	+21
Adventure · thin	4	0.4%	67/100	+75

05 COMPETITIVE BENCHMARKING

Senegal sits **fourth out of ten reportable peers** with a perception score of **70**, tied with Ghana and Rwanda and trailing only Tanzania at **73**. The gap to the leader is **3 points** — within realistic closing distance if the board addresses the themes that are suppressing the score. At the other end of the table, Senegal sits comfortably clear of South Africa (65), Egypt (64), Nigeria (62), and Morocco (39), meaning its competitive position is structurally sound rather than precarious. The priority is upward movement, not defensive positioning.

Senegal's clearest competitive advantages are in hospitality and food. On **hospitality**, Senegal's net of **46.8** is **24.1 points ahead** of the peer average of 22.7 — the largest positive gap of any reportable theme. On **food**, Senegal's net of **62.7** leads the peer average of 39.0 by **23.7 points**. These are not marginal edges; they represent genuine category leadership that destination marketing has likely under-exploited. A campaign positioning Senegal as West Africa's premier culinary and hospitality destination would be grounded in evidence, not aspiration.

The competitive weaknesses are equally clear and must be treated as strategic priorities. On **transport**, Senegal's net of **-12.8** sits **15.3 points behind** the peer average of 2.5 — meaning peers, on balance, generate positive transport sentiment while Senegal generates negative. On **safety**, Senegal's net of **-15.8** trails the peer average of -3.2 by **12.6 points**. Both gaps exceed the 10-point reporting threshold. The board should note that Tanzania — the group leader — outperforms Senegal on both dimensions, suggesting that closing these gaps is part of the path to the top of the table, not a separate concern. Net sentiment for Senegal (49.7) also trails Tanzania (58.6), Rwanda (54.3), and Kenya (52.1) despite similar or identical perception scores in some cases, reflecting the drag these friction themes are creating on the underlying emotional register.

DATA NOTE

Cameroon's sample of 16 records falls below the 50-record threshold and is excluded from all comparative findings in this section.

DATA NOTE

Morocco's perception score of 39 and negative-majority net sentiment are based on a sample of 52 records — just above the minimum threshold — and should be interpreted with some caution.

MARKET	RECORDS	PERCEPTION	NET SENTIMENT
Tanzania	1,326	73/100	+59
Ghana	1,094	70/100	+52
Rwanda	1,526	70/100	+54
Senegal	1,114	70/100	+50

Kenya	2,075	69/100	+52
Zimbabwe	1,186	68/100	+50
South Africa	2,164	65/100	+39
Egypt	2,305	64/100	+36
Nigeria	1,884	62/100	+33
Morocco	52	39/100	-21

06 TRENDS & SIGNALS

The dominant signal across the full period is the **27-point rise in perception** from the 2015 base of **40**, a trajectory that is unambiguously improving even accounting for year-to-year volatility. The peak year-level score recorded in this dataset is **79** in 2017, with a secondary peak of **77** in 2022 — both years where sample volume was sufficient and negative sentiment fell below **9%** and **14%** respectively. The post-2022 pattern shows a modest retreat: scores of **74, 69, 74** in 2023–2025, with the 2026 partial-year reading currently at **67** and a **negative share of 20.3%**. The 2024 dip to a perception score of **69** and negative share of **23.9%** was the sharpest single-year deterioration in the modern part of the series and warrants continued monitoring to determine whether 2024 was an anomaly or the start of a softer phase.

At the theme level, the most important signal is the **worsening food trend** — the only reportable theme showing a deteriorating direction in the second half of the period. Negative food sentiment rose from **10.3% to 18.2%** across the two halves, a movement of **7.8 points** that crosses the trend significance threshold. Given that food is one of Senegal's two strongest competitive advantages, any erosion of that lead deserves early attention. Scenery and hospitality are both holding stable — reassuring for the board given their centrality to the destination's identity, but not a reason for complacency given hospitality's elevated negative minority. Safety shows an improving trajectory in the movement data, a directionally encouraging development, though the safety sample remains below the threshold for the movement itself to be reported as a confirmed trend; this should be validated in the next collection cycle.

DATA NOTE

The 2015 annual sample of 32 records and the 2018 sample of 35 records both fall below the 50-record minimum, meaning those individual year-scores are indicative rather than statistically robust.

DATA NOTE

The 2026 figure covers only January through July and reflects a partial year; it cannot be compared on equal terms with full-year scores.

DATA NOTE

The safety improvement trend in the movement data is not marked reportable due to the small safety sample (19 total mentions, split 8 and 11 across halves); it is noted as indicative only.

DATA NOTE

The transport and cost movement trends are also not marked reportable in the data; their directional signals are noted but should not anchor firm conclusions.

Figure 3 — Perception over time (by year)

Perception score per period on a 0–100 scale, where 50 is neutral.

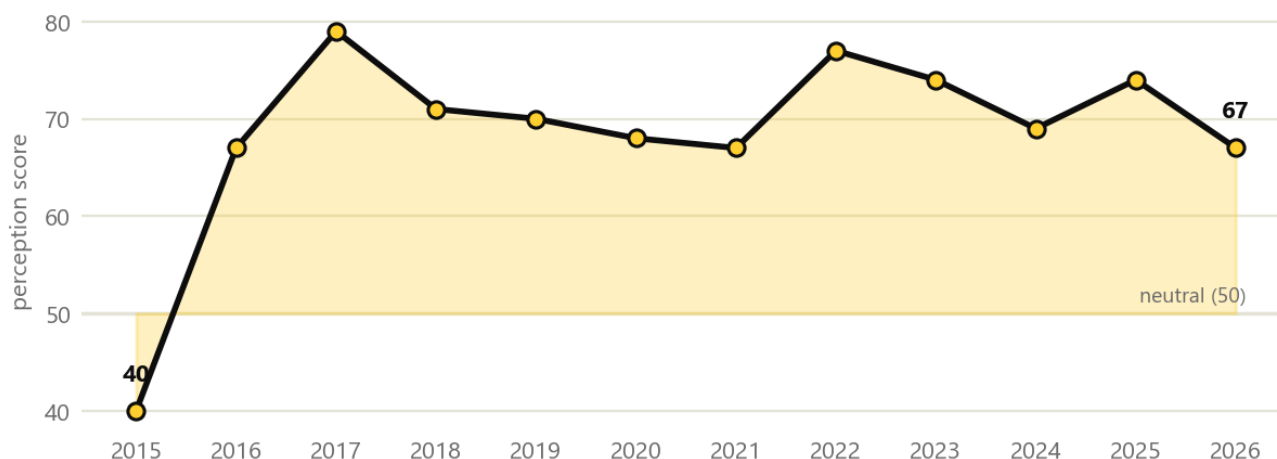
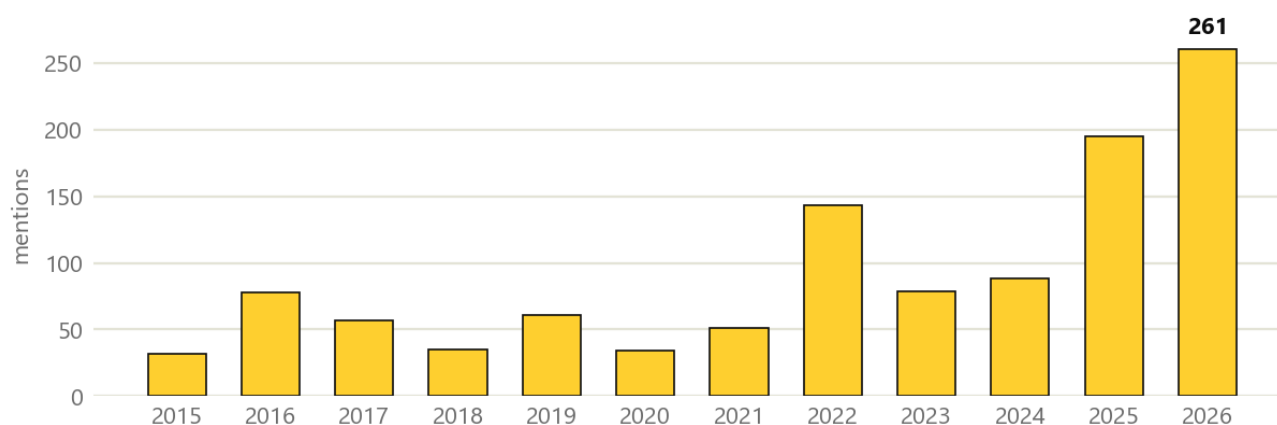


Figure 4 — Conversation volume (by year)

Records per period. Read the trend above against this: a swing on thin volume is noise.



07 RECOMMENDATIONS

The food worsening signal — negative sentiment up from **10.3% to 18.2%** across the period, the only reportable theme moving in the wrong direction — demands immediate investigation by the board's culinary and hospitality desk. The action is twofold: commission qualitative research with recent visitors to identify whether complaints concentrate on specific meal types, price points, hygiene standards, or hygienic access more broadly; and use the findings to brief restaurant associations and street-food operators in Dakar and major tourist corridors before the next high season. This matters doubly because food is also where Senegal holds its largest competitive lead, at **23.7 points ahead of the peer average**. Losing that advantage would be far more damaging than failing to close a transport gap.

Transport is the single largest gap to the peer average at **15.3 points behind**, and it is generating nearly half of all transport comments as negatives. The recommendation for destination marketing leadership is to create an honest visitor expectation framework — pre-arrival guides, in-destination orientation content, and influencer partnerships that frame transport navigation as part of the adventure rather than a failure of infrastructure. Simultaneously, the board should use these benchmarking findings in direct advocacy with the Ministry of Transport, attaching the gap figure and peer comparison to any existing infrastructure investment case. This targets both the visitor communication team and the government relations function.

Hospitality's competitive lead of **24.1 points ahead of the peer average** is the board's most underused asset. The recommendation is to build a flagship campaign positioning Senegal explicitly as a hospitality-first destination within the West African and pan-African travel market — using the food advantage as a supporting pillar. The target audience is the aspirational African traveller already engaged in regional peer markets such as Ghana and Rwanda, where the competitive data shows perception scores tied with Senegal. Converting that audience before competitors do requires moving now, while the lead is still this wide.

Finally, the segment classification gap is a data problem with strategic consequences. Only **4.6%** of records could be assigned to a traveller segment, which means the board is currently unable to make evidence-based decisions about which visitor cohort to prioritise or how to tailor messaging by trip purpose. The recommendation is to integrate structured visitor-type tagging into all future data collection partnerships — hotel feedback systems, airport intercept surveys, and social listening filters — so that the next reporting cycle can support genuine segment comparison. Until then, the indicative signal that business travellers show the weakest perception should prompt the MICE and business-travel team to audit the end-to-end corporate visitor experience, with particular attention to transport and cost friction.

DATA NOTE

Segment-specific recommendations in the final paragraph are based on indicative data only; no segment clears the 50-record threshold. Actions described are framed as audits and investigations, not as confirmed strategic pivots, to reflect this limitation.

08

METHODOLOGY & PROVENANCE

Country	Senegal
Year range	2015–2026
Aspect (any of)	all aspects
Sentiment	positive, neutral, negative
Data source	all
Relevant records only	yes
Period	February 2015 – July 2026
Records	1,114
Generated	19 Aug 2026 12:33 UTC
Narrative	Written by claude-sonnet-4-6; every figure verified against the computed data.

Evidence base: 1,038 YouTube comments, 76 YouTube transcript segments. 90% of records were attributed to this market from what the text itself is about rather than from the query that surfaced them. Sentiment is scored by a multilingual transformer; themes, emotion and visitor segment are rule-based taggers. Evidence thresholds: 50 records for a reliable view, 15 mentions before a theme can headline a finding, 5 points before a theme counts as praised or criticised, 10 points before a cross-country gap is stated. Every figure in this report is computed from the filtered records by the analysis pipeline. The written analysis interprets those figures; each number it states is verified back against them before publication, and any section that fails verification is replaced by the deterministic summary.